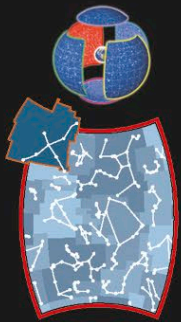


THE SWAN

Cygnus



SIZE RANKING 16

BRIGHTEST STAR
Deneb (α) 1.2

GENITIVE Cygni

ABBREVIATION Cyg

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
August–September

FULLY VISIBLE
90°N–28°S



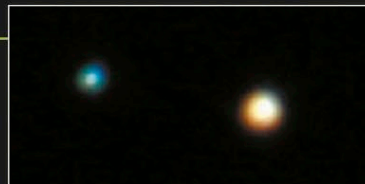
Situated in a rich area of the Milky Way, Cygnus is one of the most prominent constellations of the northern sky and contains numerous objects of interest. The relatively large constellation depicts a swan in flight,

but its main stars are arranged in the shape of a giant cross, hence its alternative popular name of the Northern Cross.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Cygnus's brightest star, Deneb—Alpha (α) Cygni—lies in the tail of the swan or at the top of the cross, depending on how the constellation is visualized. Deneb is an immensely luminous supergiant star located about 1,400 light-years away, making it the most distant 1st-magnitude star. It forms one corner of the northern Summer Triangle—a familiar sight in the skies of northern summers and southern winters—which is completed by Vega (in Lyra) and Altair (in Aquila).

The beak of the swan (or the foot of the cross) is marked by a double star, Beta (β) Cygni, known



ALBIREO β

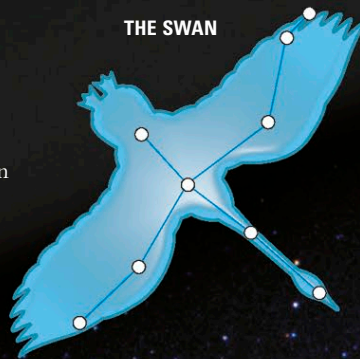
Beta (β) Cygni, also known as Albireo, marks the beak of the swan. This double star, with its strikingly contrasting colors, is easily separated with a small telescope.

as Albireo. Its two stars are sufficiently far apart that they can be seen separately with ordinary binoculars, if steadily mounted, and they are easy targets for a small telescope. The brighter star, of magnitude 3.1, is orange, and the fainter star, magnitude 5.1, is blue-green.

A similar color difference is

evident between Omicron-1 ($\omicron^1$) Cygni, a 4th-magnitude orange star, and its wide 5th-magnitude companion, 30 Cygni, which has a noticeable bluish color when seen through binoculars. A 7th-magnitude star, again bluish, and even closer to Omicron-1, can also be seen with binoculars or a small telescope.

THE SWAN



POISED IN FLIGHT

Among the stars of Cygnus, it is comparatively easy to visualize a swan, with its wings outstretched, as it flies along the Milky Way.